noted, which would be, in the end, the same as explaining them away as coincidence — or to refuse them altogether.

I do not yet have complete answers to all the questions that animate this chapter; they are part of an ongoing project. But within this space, I want to do three things. First, I will explore persistent features in the construction of narratives of Muslim threat in Myanmar. This opening section will summarize findings from the M.MAS research presented at the ANU Update, as well as draw on observation from everyday life in western Yangon 2013–2015.[3] Second, I will establish that there are both parallels and productive interrelationships between these discourses in Myanmar and those that have come to circulate worldwide since 9/11 and the expansion of the so-called global War on Terror. Establishing this will span two sections of the chapter and will require adding a new set of sources, drawn from analysis of Burmese language posts on social media and observations on their circulation in Myanmar.[4] Finally, the chapter will seek to stake out the importance of recognizing and further examining these parallels and relationships. This chapter is intended for an audience of scholars studying violence in Myanmar, for it suggests a different frame for research. But it is also for people working for peace and against conflict in Myanmar, for it suggests a set of concerns that become more legible when employing such a frame.

PARALLELS: JUSTIFYING A SENSE OF THREAT

As Myanmar was preparing for national elections in November 2015 my own country, the US, was preparing for elections as well. Republican Party candidates expressed fear and antipathy towards Islam. No Muslim should be able to be president, noted the party's frontrunners at the time (Pengelly 2015). Later, one of these leaders proposed an indiscriminate entry ban for all persons of Muslim religion — a policy that at least one poll found sixty-six per cent of Republican Party voters support (Rasmussen Reports 2015). Such sentiment in the US is not universal; other candidates, major media outlets, and sitting politicians have condemned these anti-Muslim statements and policies. But the campaign controversies were not isolated, and they illuminate a common current in American popular discourse that has a long history and has increased in force and prominence since 9/11.

As the US election campaign period began to heat up, I watched